

Episode 83: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative! *Casshern Sins* Colour Design Notes (Part 4)

I somehow managed to complete *Casshern Sins* last Friday. Looking back on about a year and a half, it feels like it was over in a flash once finished... With that sense of accomplishment mixed with the physical damage from almost three straight days and nights of all-nighters during the final push, I've been rather "spacey" since last weekend.

Ah, I need to rejoin society soon or the next job will...

Even while saying this, I'm in full WBC (World Baseball Classic) festival mode (laughs).

The Japan vs Cuba game that started early morning on the 16th (Japan time) in the San Diego round - I finished my tax filing all-nighter and watched the TV at home with that momentum. Wow, Japan's complete victory! Wonderful! Boom! Boom! Boom! Whoosh! *brass band sounds* (←apparently whistles and drums)

While watching the broadcast, the stadium stands where they were playing were totally empty. Huh? If I went there, could I maybe watch the game?

"Should I just go now? To San Diego. Wouldn't I make it in time for Japan's next game?"

The thought crossed my mind for a moment, but ah, work...

Anyway, until the WBC ends, I'm a useless person (laughs) > To all concerned parties
Now then.

Casshern Sins Colour Design Notes - this week covers episodes 13-18 of the main story. Ah, it became 5 instalments total for this series. According to the original plan, this time would go all the way to the final episode. But then, depending on the region, the final

episode hasn't aired yet... So I did the OP & ED edition last time, making it 5 instalments total.

So please bear with me a little longer.

Episode 13: "The Past Fills Before My Eyes"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

The first episode of the second half was the last broadcast of the year. Braiking Boss casually appears and, surprisingly, immediately spills various plot details to Casshern and the others before leaving. The remaining characters are all stunned! This sudden development combined with the long gap until the next broadcast over New Year's really kept viewers who had been watching the original broadcast on edge.

The key point for this episode's colour creation was the cave interior scenes. Since *Casshern Sins* screens tend to become dark easily, I had been consciously creating brighter colours for the past several episodes, but in episode 13 I wanted the cave's darkness, especially around the campfire where Braiking Boss speaks, to be dark. That's what creates atmosphere. So I created it darker with the mindset of "it's okay if it gets crushed, if it's not visible!"

When we colour designers work on character colour design, we dim or block the lighting around our monitors to make the environment dark so we can see the monitor's colour output correctly. Especially when creating colours for dark scenes, it needs to be dark. In bright ambient light situations, the monitor - or rather, your eyes - get overwhelmed by the surrounding brightness and you can't see the deep colour portions.

Since we create screens this way, when viewing, if you turn off the lighting around the TV and watch in a dark environment, you can actually see the colours within the dark

areas to some degree. While "when watching TV, keep the room bright..." often plays during TV broadcasts, for *Casshern Sins* that's forbidden (laughs).

Oh yes, episode 13 had an irregular ending change just for this episode. "Blue Shadow" (蒼い影), which was used as an insert song in the episode, was part of the CD sales promotion. Come to think of it, around this time Sera-san was passionately talking about *Casshern* on TV quite a bit.

This song was apparently one Sera-san put his heart into creating... but just between us, as my personal opinion, it didn't really fit the atmosphere of *Casshern Sins*. It was probably created from the image of the original *Casshern*. The guitar just doesn't suit *Casshern Sins* (laughs). ...Ah, that was unnecessary commentary (laughs).

Episode 14: "Truth Illuminates the Darkness"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard: Miyashita Shinpei / Direction: Ito Tatsufumi / Animation Director: Ito Tatsufumi / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Groups of ordinary robots and humans heading toward Luna's city seeking Luna's healing, and Dio's army also moving in search of Luna. Meanwhile, Casshern has recovered part of his memory and is troubled again. But he resolves to fight to protect small children, and has a rematch with Dio.

This was newlywed Ito-san's direction and animation director episode. Until the very last minute of the animation director crunch, the couple (!) were pulling all-nighters in the staff room. Actually, around this time the animation schedule was starting to get suspicious...

From around these episodes, crowds appear frequently, but I left the work mostly to the colour direction staff. The crowd colours created a nice atmosphere. I had the colour direction staff create samples by creating the atmosphere with main episode cuts and

rough colouring, then checked those. Almost all were approved in one go. They understood the colour world of *Casshern Sins* perfectly - wonderful.

Episode 15: "Death God Down"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Colour Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Down, who was Luna's guardian, reappears. The battle between Casshern and Down.

And this was our final battle of 2008 too. With the year-end/New Year schedule, December had an incredible 5 episode delivery schedule. Particularly, episode 14 was due on the 23rd and this episode 15 was due on the 29th at year-end, and well, we didn't finish (burst), ultimately crossing into the new year (laughs). On New Year's Eve morning after an all-nighter, I gazed vacantly at the sunrise from the staff room.

Episode 15's art was by Yuki Yukie-san.

She had been away from animation production sites for a while, but responded to Director Yamauchi's passionate request and took up the brush again after quite some time. Probably since *Tomorrow's Nadja*? Not only the art boards, but almost all the actual backgrounds were drawn by Yukie-san.

Yukie-san's backgrounds aren't digital backgrounds drawn on computer, but actually painted with paints on watercolour paper. These were scanned and digitised by a scanning company. Yukie-san's unique watercolour bleeding quality worked incredibly well with the photography processing bleeding, and the subtle colour mixing in the sky (clouds) and the blue of the glass tile backgrounds were particularly beautiful - the feeling of colours gently emerging on screen was exquisite.

The animation was supervised by Umakoshi too, the art was wonderful, and though it was continuous all-nighter work, I was somehow very happy and grinning throughout.

The New Year's card that arrived later from Yukie-san had one comment: "My first anime in 4 years was tough (laughs)." But she seemed to enjoy it (laughs).

Episode 16: "For the Power to Believe"

Script: Yamada Takashi / Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Yamamuro Naoyoshi, Watanabe Natsuki / Colour Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

Episode 16 hit peak animation work right across the year-end/New Year period.

The storyboard had already taken quite a bit of time, and then during year-end/New Year, animation just wouldn't come up. So it was essentially colour direction from New Year onward. The original broadcast was the third week of January. So really, we powered through by sheer force.

Usually previews are made according to the previous episode's key frame schedule and delivered together with that episode's main story, but when animation doesn't come up to this extent, you can't assemble a preview. Actually, in previous episodes there had been times when preview cuts couldn't be completed in time and we used cuts with temporary colouring in "normal" colours not used in the main episode, but even so, the animation itself was for main episode use. But for episode 16, even that was impossible, so director Kimura ended up assembling it using art boards and character colour samples (laughs).

From episode 7 onward, we had a system where different art designers handled art boards for each episode, and for episode 16 we asked Honma Sadayuki-san, who had

helped us with *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!*. Actually, I had persuaded him at the *Kitaro* wrap party (laughs).

Episode 17: "Glass Cradle"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Ito Naoyuki / Animation Director: Hayama Jun'ichi, Hamada Kunihiro, Kitao Masaru, Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Episode 17 should have entered animation earlier than episode 16, but somehow ended up with even less schedule than episode 16 (laughs).

Episode 17 begins with the shocking avant-title of maternity Leda. The laboratory where Luna was created appears, which was also a place of Leda's memories. In that place, three child-type robots were living while protecting something... Leda's main story. The episode where Leda's "female" aspects began to emerge strongly.

Horto, Hoty, Holter - robots who seem to be Luna's siblings. From that concept, when creating colours I thought to make them "a bit soft, with a thin sense of physicality." So I made their hair colour traced.

Normal character hair has solid outlines, and photography processing creates bleeding shadows around those solid lines, but with colour tracing, those solid line bleeding shadows don't appear, so I thought it would look softer. I originally thought about making eyebrows colour traced too, but there was opinion that facial expressions might dissolve and become hard to see, so I gave up. But that seemed to work out just right.

The climax, something extracted from Holter's chest - in the original storyboard it wasn't like that but something more SF-like, but the director drew a doodle-like memo sketch, and Umakoshi-kun who was watching said "ah, that might be good," so it became the setting. I created colours based on that and made a sample for the special effects staff

to work from, but... hmm, it became unexpectedly flashy and was a bit of a failure (sorry).

From episode 17, the "complete version" of ending 2 was attached (episodes 14-16 were provisional versions).

Episode 18: "The Time I Lived, The Time to Come"

Script: Yamato-ya Akira / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Maru Kanako / Colour Direction: Kunioto Kunio

From episode 13 onward, the story had been following the main plot, and in episode 17 Casshern's party's immediate clear destination was established. This deals with Lyuze's internal turmoil.

Casshern, the very person who brought ruin to her sister Lyuze - Lyuze had been pursuing Casshern with the goal of killing him, but she ends up falling in love with Casshern and falls into a dilemma. Moreover, ruin is creeping up on her too, and that fear also torments Lyuze.

Episode 18 consists almost entirely of Lyuze's dreams. At the end, Lyuze's feelings are liberated by Lyuze who appears in her dream.

This was an episode where animation director Maru-san did solo key animation, progressing with relative ease. So I feel I could work relatively leisurely. There were few characters too (laughs).

By the way, episode 18's "live-action part" became a topic of conversation in various places (laughs).

That part originally had various ideas like moving dolls with CG, but ultimately it was decided to "shoot it with humans." We used Director's single-lens digital camera EOS-1D's continuous shooting function to continuously photograph the character (model's) performance, then imported that into After Effects for processing.

The shooting was early morning the day before delivery, at Zempukuji Park not far from the studio. At 6 AM after finishing the main episode cut photography, participants were Director Yamauchi, assistant director Nakayama-san, director Kimura-kun, and me. A photo shoot in extremely light clothing during the coldest time right after dawn. Kimura-kun was the script supervisor, I was the general helper. Ladies jogging around the park pond passed by saying "Oh my, how hard, in this cold."

We rehearsed based on the storyboard to match the timing, then immediately shot for real. We finished shooting in about an hour, then warmed up for about an hour and a half at a nearby family restaurant (laughs). Then we returned to the studio, handed the data to the photography staff and had a meeting.

That's how it turned out (laughs).

I didn't think it would be blurred that much, so I was a bit surprised seeing the finished product. Well, I suppose so - showing faces clearly would be problematic. Ah, the tree stump nearby really looked like a "well" (laughs).

So now you know who was in that footage, right? (laughs)

(09.03.18)